

China

Energy-skewed price indicators

April inflation data show oil prices driving a sharp PPI rebound and higher energy CPI, while core and services inflation stayed muted. Upstream price pressures surged, but weak pass-through to downstream sectors. Soft core and services pointed to limited second round effects.

- **April: 1.2% y/y for CPI, and 2.8% y/y for PPI**
- **Bloomberg consensus forecast (Barclays): 0.9% (0.8%) y/y for CPI, and 1.8% (1.2%) y/y for PPI**
- **March: 1.0% y/y for CPI, and 0.5% y/y for PPI**

The April price data suggest that rising oil prices continued to push up PPI inflation and energy-related components of CPI, while the impact on core and services CPI remained contained, pointing to limited second-round effects. After PPI exited deflation in March for the first time since late 2022, it accelerated further to 2.8% y/y (from 0.5%), far exceeding market expectations (Bloomberg: 1.8%; Barclays: 1.2%). On a month-on-month basis, PPI surged to a post-COVID high of 1.7% in April, up from 1.0%, suggesting a lagged pass-through from earlier oil price increases, even though the rise in oil prices was less pronounced in April than in March.

The PPI breakdown shows that the rebound was mainly driven by upstream raw materials (April: 7.1% y/y vs 1.1% in March) and mining (10.6% vs 2.0%), while price pressures in downstream consumer goods (-1.0% vs -1.3%) and manufacturing sectors (1.5% vs 0.9%) remained much more muted. This suggests that downstream firms are still struggling to pass higher input costs further along the value chain. Within upstream sectors, PPI for oil and gas extraction surged to 29% y/y in April, the strongest reading since late 2022. Higher oil prices also spilled over into coal, with PPI for coal mining and washing turning positive for the first time since mid-2024.

While CPI inflation rose by 0.2pp to 1.2% y/y in April, we think this modest pickup in headline inflation mainly reflected energy-driven supply-side constraints rather than demand-led reflation or second-round effects. We estimate the contribution from energy to headline CPI rose by about 0.5pp in April, compared with only a 0.2pp increase in headline CPI inflation. This implies that, excluding energy, underlying CPI inflation actually softened in April.

Consistent with this view, several major CPI components continued to decline, including housing rents (April: -0.6% y/y vs -0.5% in March), automobiles (-1.2% vs -1.1%), and household goods and services (1.4% vs 1.5%). Moreover, core CPI remained subdued at 1.1–1.2% in March–April following the Middle East conflict, compared with an average of 1.3% in January–February. Over the same period, services CPI was broadly flat at 0.8–0.9%, slightly below its pre-conflict average of 0.9%, underscoring still-weak domestic demand.

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CPI breakdown: broadly stable core and services inflation

Looking at the breakdown, we highlight some of the key developments in the CPI data:

- **Goods CPI inflation** edged up slightly to 1.4% y/y in April from 1.3% previously, as a sharp rise in gasoline prices more than offset declines in food prices. Domestic gasoline prices surged 19.3% y/y, up from 3.8% in March, contributing around 0.56pp to headline CPI. In contrast, food CPI fell 1.6% y/y, reversing a 0.3% increase in March, driven by a faster decline in pork prices alongside softer vegetable and fruit prices.

Core CPI remained relatively resilient at 1.2% y/y, up marginally from 1.1%, but still below its pre-conflict average of 1.3% in January–February. Within core goods, gold jewellery contributed 0.2pp to headline inflation, although gold price growth moderated. Prices in other key goods categories firmed, with household appliances and clothing rising 2.6% and 1.6% y/y, respectively, together adding about 0.11pp to CPI inflation. By contrast, vehicle prices softened further, with deflation widening slightly to -1.2% y/y from -1.1%. On a month-on-month basis, vehicle prices fell 0.4% in April, marking a second consecutive decline.

- **Services CPI inflation** edged up to 0.9% y/y in April from 0.8% in March, broadly in line with its pre-conflict level in January–February. Prices of basic public services remained largely stable, with healthcare services (April: 3.4% y/y vs 3.0% in March) and education services (steady at 0.5%) continuing to rise, together contributing around 0.25pp to headline CPI. Travel-related service prices accelerated further, rising 3.7% y/y and adding about 0.13pp, reflecting the impact of higher oil prices.

Meanwhile, according to the NBS, prices of labour-intensive services increased only modestly. Pet services, dining out, housekeeping, and vehicle repair and maintenance saw price rises of 1.1%–1.4%, jointly contributing roughly 0.10pp to CPI inflation. In contrast, housing rents fell 0.6% y/y, marking the fastest pace of decline since January 2023, while data from the China Index Academy show rents in major cities declined at a much sharper rate of 3.4% y/y.

PPI breakdown: notable rise in upstream sectors

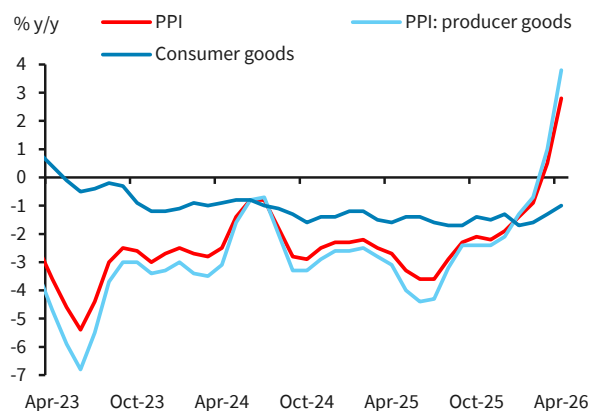
April PPI rose 2.8% after returning to positive growth in March with a 0.5% gain. The notable improvement was supported by surging prices in non-ferrous metals and energy-related sectors, with surging copper prices amid strong AI and green tech-related demand and supply concerns amid Middle East conflicts, as well as higher energy prices. On a m/m basis, PPI rose by 1.7% from 1%, the fastest pace since late 2021.

Looking at the breakdown, the producer goods PPI for mining (April: 10.6%, March: 2.0%) and raw materials (April: 7.1%, March: 1.1%) jumped, while manufacturing PPI picked up at much measured pace (April: 1.5%, March: 0.9%). However, the consumer goods PPI remained in deflation, despite some narrowing (April: -1%, March: -1.3%). Meanwhile, the decline in consumer durable goods prices continued, coming in at -0.3% in April, albeit with some moderation from -1% in March.

By sector and on a m/m basis, the PPI for energy-related sectors rose notably amid rising global oil prices. Sectors affected included oil and gas extraction (April: 18.5%, March: 15.8%), fuel processing (April: 16.4%, March: 5.8%), chemicals (April: 8.3%, March: 3.6%), chemical fiber (April: 5.6, March: 3.4%) and rubber and plastics (April: 1.7, March: 0.6%). Moreover, as market competition continues to normalize thanks to the anti-involution campaign, prices of lithium-ion battery manufacturing rose by 1.6% m/m, and prices for EV manufacturing fell at a slower pace of -0.1% (-0.8% in March). New growth drivers are gaining traction: alongside the rapid expansion of the “AI+” ecosystem and surging demand for computing power and accelerating

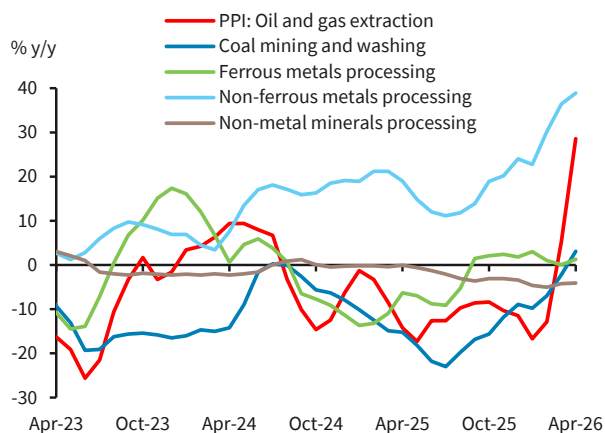
electrification process, prices of optical fiber manufacturing jumped 22.5% m/m, while external storage devices increased 3.2% m/m.

FIGURE 1. PPI exceeded market expectations...



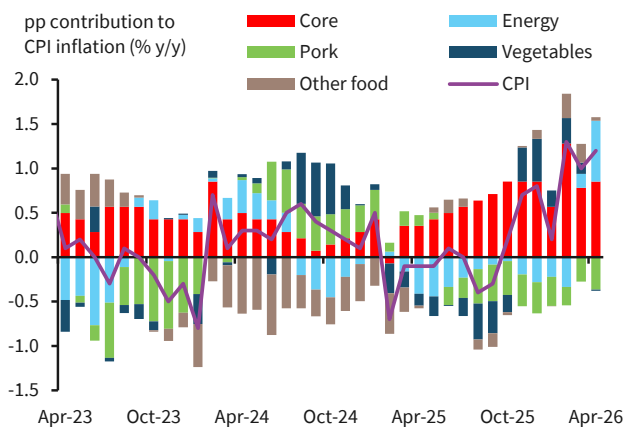
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ...led by oil and gas extraction



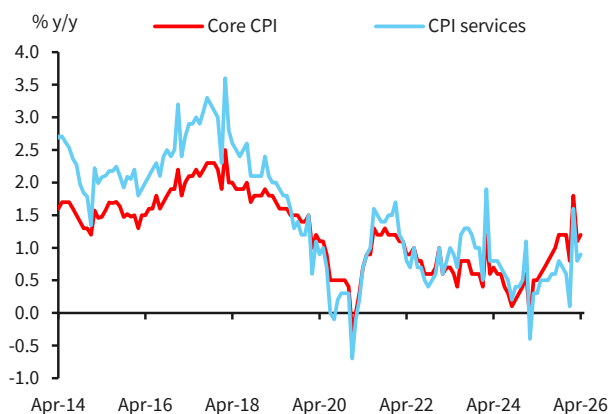
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. Without energy, CPI inflation softens



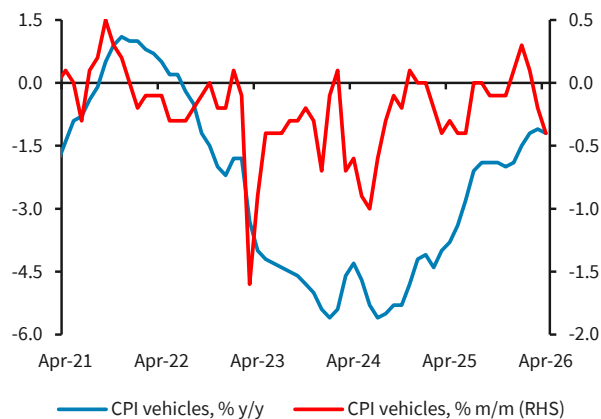
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FIGURE 4. Core and services CPI remained broadly stable



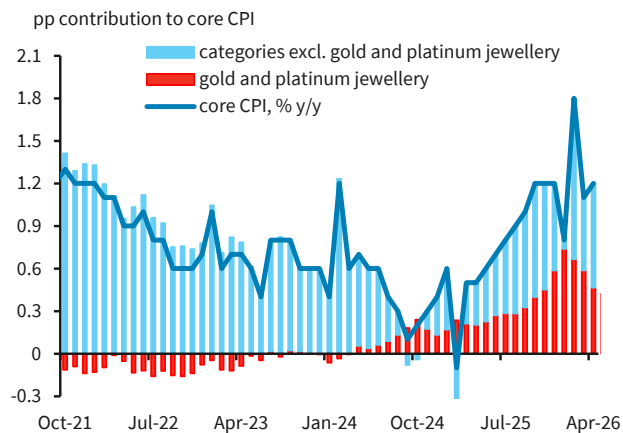
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 5. Auto prices fell again



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. Contribution from gold and platinum jewellery to CPI declined



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. CPI breakdown and PPI

	Apr-26	Mar-26	Feb-26	Jan-26	Dec-25	Nov-25	Oct-25	Sep-25	Aug-25	Jul-25	Jun-25	May-25	Apr-25
CPI %y/y													
Headline	1.2	1.0	1.3	0.2	0.8	0.7	0.2	-0.3	-0.4	0.0	0.1	-0.1	-0.1
Headline (%m/m)	0.3	-0.7	1.0	0.2	0.2	-0.1	0.2	0.1	0.0	0.4	-0.1	-0.2	0.1
Services	0.9	0.8	1.6	0.1	0.6	0.7	0.8	0.6	0.6	0.5	0.5	0.5	0.3
Services (%m/m)	0.5	-1.1	1.1	0.2	0.0	-0.4	0.2	-0.3	0.0	0.6	0.0	0.0	0.3
Goods	1.4	1.3	1.1	0.3	1.0	0.6	-0.2	-0.8	-1.0	-0.4	-0.2	-0.5	-0.3
Goods (%m/m)	0.1	-0.3	0.8	0.2	0.3	0.1	0.2	0.3	0.1	0.2	-0.1	-0.3	0.0
Food	-1.6	0.3	1.7	-0.7	1.1	0.2	-2.9	-4.4	-4.3	-1.6	-0.3	-0.4	-0.2
Food (%m/m)	-1.6	-2.7	1.9	0.0	0.3	0.5	0.3	0.7	0.5	-0.2	-0.4	-0.2	0.2
Core (excluding food and energy)	1.2	1.1	1.8	0.8	1.2	1.2	1.2	1.0	0.9	0.8	0.7	0.6	0.5
Core (excluding food and energy, %m/m)	0.2	-0.7	0.7	0.3	0.2	-0.1	0.2	0.0	0.0	0.4	0.0	0.0	0.2
Non food	1.8	1.2	1.3	0.4	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.5	0.3	0.1	0.0	0.0
Non food (%m/m)	0.7	-0.2	0.8	0.2	0.1	-0.2	0.2	-0.1	-0.1	0.5	0.0	-0.2	0.1
Housing	-0.2	-0.2	-0.2	-0.1	-0.2	0.0	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1
Recreation	1.3	1.1	2.0	0.0	0.9	0.8	0.9	0.8	1.0	0.9	1.0	0.9	0.7
Transportation	4.6	0.9	-0.7	-3.4	-2.6	-2.3	-1.5	-2.0	-2.4	-3.1	-3.7	-4.3	-3.9
Medical	2.2	1.9	1.9	1.7	1.8	1.6	1.4	1.1	0.9	0.5	0.4	0.3	0.2
Clothing	1.5	1.6	1.9	1.9	1.7	1.9	1.7	1.7	1.8	1.7	1.6	1.5	1.3
Household facilities	1.4	1.5	2.8	2.6	2.2	2.1	1.9	2.2	1.8	1.2	0.7	0.1	0.2
PPI %y/y	2.8	0.5	-0.9	-1.4	-1.9	-2.2	-2.1	-2.3	-2.9	-3.6	-3.6	-3.3	-2.7
PPI %m/m	1.7	1.0	0.4	0.4	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.0	0.0	-0.2	-0.4	-0.4	-0.4

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

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